

STARTER

Field-by-Field Application Walkthrough

United Arab Emirates - Tourist Visa (pre-arranged e-visa route)

VERIFY BEFORE YOU APPLY

Fees, forms, and processing times change without notice. This guide reflects publicly documented procedures as commonly published; treat every dollar figure, form number, and timeline here as a starting point, and confirm the current version on the official government site before you submit anything or pay any fee.

Before you start: check which of the three routes applies to you

The UAE doesn't have a single, uniform tourist visa process the way many other countries do. Depending on your nationality, one of three routes applies:

- Visa-exempt: nationals of a number of countries can enter without any visa at all, for a set number of days
- Visa-on-arrival: nationals of a number of other countries can get a visa stamped or issued on arrival at a UAE airport, usually free or for a fee, without applying in advance
- Pre-arranged e-visa required: nationals of most other countries must have a visa arranged and approved before travelling - you cannot simply arrive and apply

CHECK YOUR NATIONALITY'S ROUTE FIRST

This guide covers the pre-arranged e-visa route, since that's what most applicants buying visa-preparation guidance actually need. If your passport qualifies for visa-exempt or visa-on-arrival entry, you don't need to apply for anything in advance - confirm your specific status on the ICP's official website or with your airline before assuming you need an e-visa.

The sponsor model

Unlike most Western tourist visas, individual applicants generally don't apply directly to a UAE government portal. Instead, a sponsor applies on your behalf and is formally responsible for the application:

- An airline (commonly Emirates, Etihad, flydubai, and others) sponsoring passengers flying with them
- A hotel or licensed tour operator/travel agency, often as part of a booking
- A UAE resident or citizen sponsoring a personal guest

Your role is usually to provide your passport details, photo, and any supporting documents to your chosen sponsor, who submits the application through their own approved channel.

What you'll need to provide your sponsor

- A passport-style digital photo
- Your passport bio page, valid for at least 6 months beyond your planned entry date
- Your travel dates and, often, a return or onward flight booking
- Proof of health insurance covering your stay - mandatory for UAE tourist visas
- Any fee your sponsor requires, on top of the government visa fee itself

Visa types and lengths

Type	Notes
30-day single entry	One entry, 30 days from entry date, extendable in some cases
30-day multiple entry	Multiple entries within the visa's validity window
60-day single/multiple entry	Longer stay/validity versions of the above
96-hour transit visa	For short layovers, separate from a tourist visa
5-year multiple-entry tourist visa	For eligible nationalities meeting a separate, published financial-means requirement - materially different application process from the standard short visas covered in this guide

Processing

Pre-arranged e-visas are commonly processed within a few working days once your sponsor submits your application - often faster than many other countries' tourist visas. There's no interview. If approved, you'll receive a printed e-visa document (usually by email as a PDF), not a sticker in your passport - print it and carry a copy, since it's what's checked at check-in and on arrival.